# Ankle sprain

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**Archive note:** English text snapshot of the official patient-information webpage. Navigation was removed; the medical content was not translated.

Ankle sprain

This leaflet will explain the following.

What an ankle sprain is.

What the symptoms of an ankle sprain are.

What causes an ankle sprain, and how it's diagnosed.

What the treatment options are.

What exercises you need to do.

We hope this leaflet answers some of the questions you may have. If you have any further questions or concerns, please speak to a member of your healthcare team.

## What is an ankle sprain?

Ankle ligament tears

An ankle sprain occurs when the ligaments that connect bones in the ankle are stretched or torn. This is often due to a sudden twist by a fall or awkward landing.

The ligaments on the outer side are most often affected. These ligaments are known as the anterior talofibular ligament and calcaneofibular ligament.

How common is it?

Lateral ankle sprains are the most common lower limb musculoskeletal injury in people. Up to 7 in 10 people will experience this in their life time.

## What are the symptoms?

Swollen and bruised ankle

## Symptoms can include the following.

Pain and tenderness around the ankle, swelling or bruising.

Movement of the ankle can be painful or stiff. This may make weight bearing or walking difficult. Try and move and weightbear on the ankle as pain allows.

In severe cases, you may hear a pop when you injure your ankle. This sound may mean the ligaments in your ankle have been stretched or torn.

These symptoms will improve with time, but may last up to 6 to 8 weeks.

What causes an ankle sprain?

An ankle sprain can happen by twisting or rolling the ankle.

If you have previously had any ankle injuries, it may increase your risk of spraining your ankle, as:

your ankle may not have completely recovered from a previous injury, which has led to the ankle being weak; or

your rehabilitation after this injury was poor or not completed.

It is important to follow the correct rehabilitation and guidance given by your therapist.

How is an ankle sprain diagnosed?

A healthcare professional will ask you questions about how you injured your ankle and how it feels.

They will complete a physical examination of your ankle.

Depending on the results of this, an x-ray may also help the diagnosis.

What treatments are available?

What treatment we recommend will depend on:

your injury; and

whether you have any other injuries to your ankle.

Elevated (raised) ankle

Your doctor or nurse will explain the treatment they recommend for you. If you have any questions, please ask.

For the first few days it is important to reduce any pain and swelling. This can be done by applying ice and elevating (raising) your ankle.

You can also use some compression on your ankle. This applies a gentle pressure to support the ankle, typically using a bandage or support.

How do I use the ice?

Place a bag of frozen peas or ice cubes into a damp tea towel.

Rest the towel over the affected area for no more than 10 minutes.

Do not apply the ice for more than 10 minutes unless told to by your therapist, as you could cause a burn to your skin. If you are concerned about your skin, please stop your treatment and speak to your therapist.

Caution:

ice can cause burns, so do not put it directly on your skin, always use a towel. Protect sensitive skin with baby oil.

Repeat every 2 hours.

Continue to use this treatment for as long as you feel it helps.

Why is it important to start rehabilitation early?

Even though it may be painful to start with, start trying to complete some gentle movements with the ankle. For example, ankle circles, ankle pumps, or writing the alphabet with your ankle.

To help with pain, you may want to use pain relief (such as paracetamol).

Do not use ibuprofen in the first 48 hours following the injury, as it slows healing.

After a few days it is important to get the ankle moving. This will help your ankle to move again, as soon as your symptoms allow you too. Pain can still be normal at this stage, so complete the movements as your pain allows. Movement will help blood flow to the injured area and will help healing.

## Exercises: days 1 to 2

Alphabet: sitting or lying down, trace the alphabet with your foot. Complete for 30 to 60 seconds, 3 times a day or as your pain allows.

Ankle pumps: sitting or lying down, briskly bend and straighten your ankles. Complete for 30 to 60 seconds, 3 times a day or as your pain allows.

Ankle circles: laying on your back, moving your foot to form a circle. Complete for 30 to 60 seconds, and then change direction. Complete 3 times a day, or as your pain allows.

Single leg stand: stand straight with your feet close together. Lift one leg off the floor. Hold for 10 to 30 seconds and lower your leg. To start with, you may need to use a surface to help your balance. Repeat 2 to 5 times, twice a day or as your pain allows.

## Exercises: day 3 onwards

Continue with the above exercises, if by day 3 you are:

still struggling with the exercises above; or

the exercises below are too painful.

Keep trying to progress to the exercises below until they are tolerable or your pain has reduced when completing them.

Please continue with ice treatment and elevation, alongside the exercises.

Aim to perform the following exercises:

3 to 5 days a week.

2 to 3 sets, of 8 to 12 repetitions.

Rest for 60 to 120 seconds between each set.

Isometric plantarflexion; sit or lay down with your legs stretched out. Place your forefoot of the unaffected leg under your affected leg. Try to push your forefoot down with the affected leg, but make the unaffected leg resist the movement. Hold the position without moving the foot.

Isometric dorsiflexion; sit or lay down with your legs stretched out. Place your forefoot of the unaffected leg under your affected leg. Try to push your forefoot up with the affected leg, but make the unaffected leg resist the movement. Hold the position without moving the foot.

Isometric inversion; sit with your leg stretched out. Place your unaffected foot on the inside of your affected foot. Try to tilt the foot inwards, while resisting the movement from the unaffected foot.

Isometric eversion; sit with your legs stretched out. Place your unaffected foot on the outside of your affected foot. Try to tilt the affected foot outwards, while resisting the movement with the other foot.

Seated or standing calf raises; stand on both feet with your hands on a chair or table for balance. Raise onto your tip toes without bending your knees. Slowly lower your feet back to the starting position. This exercise can also be done while sitting on a chair. Have your feet flat on the floor, and raise onto your tip toes.

How successful are the treatments?

Most people recover well from ankle sprains. Up to 4 in 10 people with ankle sprains can have ongoing weakness, and sprains and strains in the future. You may be able to avoid this happening to you, by following the advice in this leaflet.

## What should I do if my symptoms are not improving?

Most patients do not have a follow-up appointment at the hospital. Most ankle sprains will feel better after 2 weeks. However, if you still have pain, swelling and bruising after 2 weeks, contact your GP. They will be able to give you further advice or refer you for physiotherapy.

Please return to the Urgent Treatment Centre, if after 3 days you:

are unable to weight bear; or

you have worsening pain or swelling into the lower leg.

Urgent Treatment Centres (UTCs): East Kent Hospitals

Urgent Treatment Centres can be found at the following East Kent Hospitals.

Buckland Hospital, Dover, Kent

Kent and Canterbury Hospital, Canterbury

Queen Elizabeth Queen Mother (QEQM) Hospital, Margate

Royal Victoria Hospital, Folkestone

William Harvey Hospital, Ashford

## References

Anon, (n.d.). Ankle Sprain | NHS Lanarkshire

Mungo, A. and Constant, D. (2023) Recurrent Ankle Sprain.

Sprains and Strains (2024) NHS choices

[Web sites last accessed 17 June 2026]

What do you think of this leaflet?

We welcome feedback, whether positive or negative, as it helps us to improve our care and services.

If you would like to give us feedback about this leaflet, please fill in our short online survey. Either scan the QR code below, or use the web link. We do not record your personal information, unless you provide contact details and would like to talk to us some more.

Giving feedback about this leaflet

https://www.smartsurvey.co.uk/s/MDOBU4/

If you would rather talk to someone instead of filling in a survey, please call the Patient Voice Team.

Patient Voice Team

Telephone: 01227 868605

Email